Robodebt and Helm Failure

Pre-analysis question register

Version: 1.0 — proposed questions, not a completed statistical analysis plan.
Prepared: 13 November 2026.
Study: Existing, already-scored, blinded CAMS records for Australia, the Morrison government, Cabinet, the prime minister and CES/Centrelink, subject to verification of the actual dataset boundaries.
Access statement: No CAMS files have been supplied to, inspected or analysed by the assistant preparing this register. The investigator reports that scoring is complete, data are blinded, and analysis has not begun; this register does not independently verify those conditions.
Purpose: Commit questions, rival explanations and limits of inference before examination or unblinding. Numerical mappings and analysis specifications require a separately frozen implementation addendum before analytical access.

Evidence and the prior

The proposed Helm-failure interpretation has a substantial evidentiary basis, but its strongest motivational claims remain hypotheses. The Royal Commission documented failures of ministerial responsibility, misleading information, ineffective checks and political treatment of welfare recipients; its findings concerning Alan Tudge included the use of recipients' information to discourage criticism, which Tudge disputed.[1][2]

Those findings do not establish that Morrison personally designed Robodebt chiefly to demoralise political opponents, that recipients were selected by political affiliation, or that allies experienced pleasure in their suffering. Such claims require evidence identifying the actor, conduct, knowledge, purpose and audience; a CAMS signature alone cannot establish them. The Commission also expressly recognised that anti-welfare political rhetoric had a longer, cross-party history, making an unrestricted claim of Australian historical uniqueness unjustified without comparative research.[^1]

The institutional alternative must receive a fair test. In 2026 the NACC found serious corrupt conduct by two officials concerning specified acts of misleading others; it did not find corrupt conduct by the other four referred individuals, and its inquiry was explicitly narrower than the entire scheme. These findings neither settle every question of political responsibility nor permit the alternative of bureaucratic misinformation to be omitted.[^3]

Declared substantive prior: The investigator suspects that executive political incentives distorted lawful welfare administration, weakened correction and imposed avoidable demoralisation on recipients and critics. The stronger propositions of personal hostile purpose, partisan targeting, pleasure in suffering and historical uniqueness are not assumed.
Methodological stance: evidence contradicting executive primacy must receive the same reporting prominence as evidence supporting it.

Boundaries before testing

Morrison became prime minister on 24 August 2018, after serving as social services minister from December 2014 and treasurer from 2015 to 2018. Robodebt's development and operation crossed these roles and multiple prime ministerships, so a prime-minister-only series cannot by itself locate responsibility for the scheme's origin.[4][1]

CES and Centrelink must not be treated as interchangeable labels. Official agency history identifies the Commonwealth Employment Service as an employment service established in 1946 and Centrelink as an agency launched in 1997. Any long-run combined series requires an explicit account of institutional succession, functions, discontinuities and scoring comparability.[^5]

In this register, **Helm failure** means failure to direct, supervise or correct policy in accordance with a separately specified lawful public mandate. It does not mean electoral defeat, low coherence by definition, lack of political effectiveness, or a clinical assessment of a person. High internal coordination can coexist with harmful direction; low capacity is not the only possible adverse signature. These are proposed study definitions, not changes to the CAMS codebook.

Keep the prime minister's office, Cabinet, portfolio ministers, senior administration, frontline staff and recipients analytically distinct. Government-level and person-level records cannot be substituted for one another. A mismatch between them is itself potentially informative.

Six priority questions

Q01–Q06 are the proposed primary family. Their predicted patterns are commitments to be operationalised before access, not results. No primary claim may be rescued by switching dimensions, inventing a composite or moving a date after inspecting the data. Where a pattern cannot be measured with the existing codebook and dataset, classify that question as **not testable**, rather than manufacture an indicator.

ID	Question to register	Predicted pattern under executive-distortion hypothesis	Finding that would weaken it
Q01	**Does an adverse executive change precede deterioration in Centrelink's recipient-facing functioning?**	A pre-defined executive signature leads the agency signature at a lag the sampling interval can resolve.	Agency deterioration clearly precedes executive change; executive change is absent; or chronology contradicts the predicted order. Simultaneous observations leave direction unresolved.
Q02	**Does executive policy-execution strength coexist with worsening recipient-facing functioning?**	Maintained or increased coordination or execution capability at executive level alongside deterioration in independently defined lawful-service outcomes.	Executive and agency deterioration are general and parallel, without the predicted asymmetry. High executive coherence alone is not corroboration.

ID	Question to register	Predicted pattern under executive-distortion hypothesis	Finding that would weaken it
Q03	**Does corrective information become less effectively connected to executive action?**	A pre-defined Archive–Helm or oversight–executive mismatch increases alongside independently documented failures to revise policy after credible warnings.	Warning transmission and remedial action remain effective, or the proposed mismatch is absent. A symmetric similarity matrix alone cannot establish information suppression or direction.
Q04	**After independently dated warnings, does harmful policy persist without a proportionate corrective response?**	Pre-defined adverse service indicators persist beyond locked warning dates while the executive fails to trigger substantive revision within the locked response window.	Prompt, substantial correction follows warnings, or the alleged persistence is not observable. Responsibility also depends on who actually received the warning.
Q05	**Is the proposed signature more concentrated in Robodebt-relevant institutions than in Australia generally?**	The relevant executive–agency pattern is larger than the locked national or available comparison pattern after accounting for common trends.	Comparable deterioration occurs broadly, with no programme-specific concentration. An aggregate containing Centrelink is not an independent control.
Q06	**Does ending income-averaged debt raising precede improvement in the affected service functions?**	Improvement occurs in the pre-specified subsequent window in the functions expected to respond, rather than merely in an aggregate score.	Those functions do not improve, improve earlier, or change equally in unaffected functions. Inadequate follow-up or concurrent shocks makes the result inconclusive.

These are distinct propositions. Agreement on one is not automatic agreement on the others. A six-question majority vote must not become an improvised test of intentional cruelty; any joint decision rule requires its own advance specification.

Pathway questions

These questions are secondary unless explicitly promoted in the implementation addendum before access.

Q07 — Location. Where is the earliest resolvable departure: the prime minister's record, Cabinet, portfolio-minister records, senior administration, frontline operations, or the national system? Does the dataset actually distinguish those levels?

Q08 — Vertical divergence. Do Cabinet and departmental leadership remain aligned with one another while becoming less aligned with frontline staff and recipients, or is fragmentation already present within the executive?

Q09 — Upward transmission. Do available observations distinguish adverse information not being generated, not being transmitted, being distorted in transmission, and being received but disregarded? If they do not, which mechanisms must remain unidentified?

Q10 — Coordination versus correction. Is strong internal executive coherence associated with better correction, or with persistence of a policy despite adverse evidence? What independent observation establishes that correction was warranted?

Q11 — Administrative abstraction. Does any existing abstraction measure track loss of access to individual circumstances or proxy-driven administration? Can it distinguish abstraction that improves service from abstraction that overrides relevant evidence?

Q12 — Burden displacement. Is maintained executive or administrative performance accompanied by increased stress or reduced effective capacity among staff and recipients? Are these populations measured separately rather than inferred from a national Hands score?

Q13 — Recognition versus remedy. After a warning reaches a responsible office, how long elapses before acknowledgement, investigation, operational suspension and substantive remedy? Are these separate stages rather than one discretionary correction date?

Q14 — Persistence and repair. Does termination of the contested practice restore the affected relationships, or do stress and impaired functioning persist during refunds, litigation and institutional repair? Are those later outcomes within the frozen dataset?

Rival explanation questions

Q15 — Bureaucratic origin. Are the observations more consistent with administrative initiative or misinformation subsequently accepted by ministers than with an executive-originating distortion? What evidence would require withdrawal of executive primacy?

Q16 — Fiscal objective. Can savings targets and pressure to recover revenue explain the pattern without an additional hypothesis of partisan hostility? What observation discriminates those accounts rather than merely fitting both?

Q17 — Technical failure. Can data quality, automation design and delivery constraints explain the initial failure? If so, can they also explain persistence after the relevant legal and human consequences were known?

Q18 — Distributed failure. Are failures spread across ministers, departments, legal services and oversight bodies sufficiently to favour a multi-institutional explanation over a single-Helm account?

Q19 — Inherited conditions. Does comparable deterioration precede the relevant ministerial appointment or government period? If the baseline is unavailable, must the claim of a new executive-induced break remain unresolved?

Q20 — General pressure. Do staffing constraints, workload, wider welfare-policy changes or other common shocks explain the Centrelink trajectory as well as, or better than, the preferred account?

Q21 — Role transition. Does the signature change when Morrison becomes prime minister, or is continuity across his earlier roles and other prime ministers the more defensible description? Does the time resolution permit that distinction?

Q22 — Placebos and negative controls. Does the same locked detection procedure find similar apparent failures at independently selected non-event dates or in suitable comparison functions? Are false alarms frequent enough to undermine specificity?

Intent and political targeting

Q23–Q30 require documentary, behavioural, comparative or audience evidence beyond CAMS state vectors. If those sources are absent, record **not established**, not a numerical proxy for intent.

Q23 — Intended harm or accepted harm. What evidence distinguishes a deliberate purpose to demoralise from indifference, reckless disregard, tolerated collateral harm, or mistaken belief in legitimate enforcement? Are creation and later defence of the programme assessed separately?

Q24 — Political foes. Who precisely are the alleged targets: welfare recipients generally, individual public critics, opposition politicians, advocacy organisations, or people selected by political affiliation? What evidence supports each category without assuming recipients are opposition voters?

Q25 — Silence as an objective. Do contemporaneous records show an intention to discourage criticism or advocacy, and can that objective be attributed to particular actors rather than retrospectively to Cabinet as a whole?

Q26 — Chilling effect. Is reduced public criticism supported by evidence distinguishing intimidation from changed media attention, altered policy, exhaustion, reduced case numbers or other explanations?

Q27 — Political benefit. Is there evidence of an intended electoral or coalition-building benefit, and separately of a benefit actually realised? Does the analysis avoid treating an assumed benefit as proof of motive?

Q28 — Schadenfreude. Is there direct evidence that identifiable officials, supporters or audiences expressed pleasure specifically at others' suffering, rather than support for lawful debt recovery, fiscal restraint or punishment of proven fraud? Can prevalence be assessed rather than illustrated with selected anecdotes?

Q29 — Personal attribution. Which findings can legitimately be attributed to Morrison personally, which to portfolio ministers, which to Cabinet collectively and which to officials? Does any CAMS measure have validated person-level interpretability?

Q30 — Historical exceptionality. Under an independently selected Australian comparison set and fixed dimensions—scale, unlawfulness, automation, intimidation, targeting and correction delay—is Robodebt an outlier? If there is no such comparison set, will the claim of being without precedent be withheld?

Validity and falsification

Q31 — Score provenance. Were the scores produced from contemporaneous evidence, later investigations, or both? Which sources, dates, prompts, model versions, human judgements and revision steps contributed to each observation?

Q32 — Actual blinding. Who has seen values, plots, summaries, entity keys, dates or earlier related runs? Are only names concealed, or also chronology and outcomes? Could an analyst

recognise entities from their trajectories? Record suspected recognition before reveal.

Q33 — Historical leakage. Could scorers or scoring models have known the Robodebt outcome even when labels were masked? If retrospective knowledge entered the scores, will the study be reported as retrospective discrimination rather than historical forecasting?

Q34 — Independent corroboration. Do the CAMS scores and claimed validation outcomes derive from overlapping documents or models? If so, can independent evidence be used, or must apparent agreement be described as shared-source consistency rather than external validation?

Q35 — Comparable scales. Are node definitions, score anchors and organisational boundaries stable across national, Cabinet, prime-minister and CES/Centrelink datasets? Which comparisons are invalid if they are not?

Q36 — Time and dependence. How many genuinely independent time intervals exist? Can annual observations resolve the proposed lead–lag sequence? Are nested entities, repeated dimensions and serial dependence prevented from becoming artificial replication?

Q37 — Specification stability. Do the primary results survive the frozen, substantively justified alternatives for baseline, lag, event window and missingness? Are all specified alternatives reported rather than only favourable versions?

Q38 — Incremental CAMS value. Does CAMS add discrimination, timing, localisation or explanatory economy beyond a locked simpler comparator such as common trends and documented event timing? What result would show that CAMS adds little?

Q39 — Symmetry of judgement. Would the same procedure and evidentiary standard identify Helm failure in another party's government? Can a blinded independent analyst reach comparable classifications without being told the preferred political interpretation?

Q40 — Genuine defeat conditions. What exact combination of contrary chronology, absent asymmetry, effective correction, superior rival explanation, false positives or source leakage would require rejecting or materially narrowing the executive-distortion hypothesis? Will that finding be stated prominently?

Freeze the implementation

A question register is not, on its own, a fully specified confirmatory protocol. Preregistration distinguishes planned from exploratory work; existing-data studies particularly require disclosure of prior exposure and decisions that might otherwise depend on observed results.[6] [7]

The following decisions must be completed in an implementation addendum without examining analytical values. Missing decisions do not authorise discretionary choices after reveal: the affected question becomes exploratory or not testable.

Item to freeze	Required commitment
1. Dataset manifest	Exact files, custodians, versions, SHA-256 digests, date ranges, sampling frequency, entity definitions and lineage. Keep identifying material sealed if required.
2. Access declaration	A person-by-person record of prior access, scoring involvement, known history, earlier runs and what remains concealed.
3. CAMS codebook	Version, scale direction, anchors, existing formulae and the precise observable signature for each primary question. No new psychological interpretation of a formula.
4. Primary estimands	The quantity each question will estimate: change, difference, ordering, divergence or recovery. Fix which raw variables or existing composites are used.
5. Events and baselines	Exact dates and windows, selected from independently specified evidence before score access. Distinguish warning issuance from verified receipt.
6. Resolution rules	Smallest distinguishable lag; treatment of same-period changes; required pre/post observations; mandatory unresolvable or not-testable classifications.
7. Analysis method	One designated primary method per question, its assumptions and software. With sparse observations, favour clearly labelled descriptive tests over unjustified causal modelling.
8. Thresholds and uncertainty	Substantively meaningful effects, measurement error, uncertainty method and decision criteria fixed from the codebook or external justification, not the observed result.
9. Multiple testing	Define the Q01–Q06 family. If valid p-values are used, proposed default: two-sided tests, Holm adjustment across the six planned claims, family-wise alpha 0.05; an unavailable test counts as no evidence, not permission to promote another. Fix any alternative beforehand.
10. Missingness and nesting	Exclusions, interpolation policy, institution changes, overlapping populations, derived aggregates and shared-source dependence. No selective deletion.
11. Robustness and comparators	A finite list of alternative windows and baselines, negative controls and simpler models. State whether any comparison dataset is genuinely available.
12. Release and reporting	Custody of the identity key; execution order; stopping rule; amendment procedure; complete results table including unfavourable and inconclusive outcomes.

If the existing CAMS coupling matrix is calculated as symmetric similarity between scores, it cannot by construction identify one-way political commands or suppression of messages. Directional claims require separately observed chronology or interactions. Derived network metrics are not independent replications of the input scores.

Do not infer a minister's feelings from a system-level Capacity-minus-Stress value, or infer hostile intent merely from high Abstraction. Any interpretation linking a CAMS construct to personal cognition, motive or emotion requires separate construct validation.

Classification rules

Every question receives one of five reporting labels: **supported within the stated design; contradicted; inconclusive; not testable; exploratory**. Evidence of temporal precedence or association is not by itself proof of causation. An insignificant result is not evidence of equivalence; a claim of meaningful absence requires adequate precision and an advance equivalence criterion.

Keep separate verdicts for **executive responsibility**, **mechanism of administrative distortion**, **deliberate intimidation**, **partisan targeting**, **pleasure in suffering** and **historical exceptionality**. Agreement with the first two does not establish the last four. No aggregate verdict may be labelled a finding of legal corruption or criminal liability.

The preferred explanation should be narrowed if the data favour agency-led failure, widespread institutional dysfunction, common resource constraints, effective early correction or no distinctive CAMS signal. A documented historical failure and an unsuccessful CAMS explanation can both be true.

Hash and timestamp procedure

Freeze the exact bytes of this register, the completed implementation addendum, the dataset manifest, scoring codebook and analysis code. Hash each file and preserve those digests in a manifest. A checksum commits to a file's contents; the manifest must itself receive an independently verifiable time record.

An OSF registration can archive responses, files and metadata in a timestamped, immutable record; existing-data registration should disclose prior knowledge and access. Where confidentiality requires a hash-only commitment, a completed OpenTimestamps proof can establish that the committed material existed no later than a particular anchoring time, without establishing its truth or authorship.[8][9][10][11]

Recommended sequence: **freeze questions and implementation → freeze data and code → calculate hashes → obtain and preserve external timestamp evidence → run the locked analysis under the recorded blinding → freeze results and suspected identities → release the identity key → conduct separately labelled historical interpretation.** If named event windows require earlier identity access, disclose that limitation instead of describing the whole analysis as fully blind.

The accompanying SHA-256 checksum is a file-integrity record only. Neither the preparation date nor a locally generated checksum is an independently verified preregistration timestamp. No external registration or timestamp has been obtained through preparation of this document. Any amendment must create a new version with its own hash, time evidence and access-state declaration; preserve the original.

References

1. Report - The beginning of 2017 was the point at which Robodebt's unfairness, probable illegality and cruelty ...
2. What did the Robodebt royal commission find about ... - ... robodebt-morrison-tudge-porter-robert/102575414. Link copied. Share ... abuse of that power. It ...
3. Operation Myrtleford - Executive Summary | National Anti ... - Operation Myrtleford - Executive Summary Operation Myrtleford was an investigation into the 6 person...
4. Scott Morrison | naa.gov.au - On 24 August 2018, Scott Morrison became Australia's 30th prime ... A Cabinet reshuffle in December ...

5. Who we are - About us - the Commonwealth Employment Service was created to help job seekers find paid employment. In 1997, C...
6. Preregistration - About Preregistration , you will identify whether existing data is included in your planned analysis...
7. Preregistering secondary data analyses? Yes, you can! - Preregistering secondary data analyses can make your work and science as a whole more transparent, r...
8. OSF Registries Improve Transparency and Rigor of Research - OSF Registries offers various registration templates, enabling researchers to register according to ...
9. Choosing the Right Preregistration Template: A Guide ... - Preregistration is the practice of posting a time-stamped, read-only version of your study plan to a...
10. OpenTimestamps.org - A timestamp proves that some data existed prior to some point in time. OpenTimestamps defines a set ...
11. OpenTimestamps - It defines a portable format for provable timestamps that demonstrate a piece of data existed at or ...